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SEEING RED A Bajrang Dal protest demanding removal of the Aurangzeb tomb in Sambhajinagar, Mar. 17

appetite is insatiable. Following Aurangzeb's grave, the Taj Mahal and the Lal Qila could be next in line. After all, in the Hindutva imagination, the Taj Mahal was originally a Shiva temple and Lal Qila was the Lal Kot constructed by the Tomar dynasty.

The point, therefore, is to assess this project. Is it capable of carrying Indian society into a prosperous and happy future? Is it even authentic historically? Ironically, the project itself does not seem confident in this regard and hence takes recourse to hurt sentiments instead of reasoned discourse. Like any totalitarian political project, Hindutva also heavily depends on a constant arousal of passionate rage and hurt and has acquired the vocal support of large sections of our mass media which are willingly fanning the fires instead of providing space for serious discussions on real issues of governance. The real content here is political, not historical, otherwise the demands for removing the vestiges of the British raj would also be made with the same passion. The political message is clear—Hindus are the *nation* here, all others, and particularly the Muslims, can live only as a matter of grace, not as a matter of right.

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Political Hindutva's existential dependence on the Muslim as the permanently frightening Other has historical roots, but cannot be addressed merely through historians' interventions, howsoever authentic and sincere. It can be addressed only through the politics of a future-oriented, inclusive and democratic idea of India, which formed the core of our national movement and had so far been generally hegemonic. Hindutva seeks to replace this idea with its own version, claiming civilisational authenticity.

This claim hardly holds water as it refuses to see the dynamic character of Indian cultural experience and its diversity. On the other hand, the inclusive idea of India recognises both the long continuity of Indian civilisation and its historically evolving diversity. Jawaharlal Nehru most appropriately compared Indian civilisation to a palimpsest carrying traces of so many writings over the centuries. The Indian national movement undertook the task of evolving a modern nation out of this palimpsest-like civilisation.

This undertaking required, and still requires, negotiating historical tensions, caste, community and cultural fault-lines within the framework of a shared imagination of a humane and democratic society. It hardly matters to Akbar, Shahjahan and Aurangzeb what you do with their various memorials, but it matters a lot to the present and future of India as a civilisation and as a nation-state. Can we build a happy future on the basis of constant demonisation of some Indians merely on the basis of their faith system? Can a society afford to be constantly angry over its past? Can we erase history by demolishing a grave and by utterly simplifying the character of any historical figure and his/ her times? Do we prefer to preserve the palimpsest of Indian civilisation or tear it apart? Do we imagine ourselves as building the edifice of the future or digging up the graves of past? This is the real question, and our future depends on how it is answered. ■

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